10 OPENERS, AND WHAT TO SAY WHEN IT GOES OFF TRACK

What to Say in the First 30 Seconds of Your Meeting

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1 When people are still joining, start anyway

Start at the time on the invite. Catch people up in one line when they arrive.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Let's give it a couple more minutes for people to join."
> Instead say: "Let's start. I'll catch people up as they join."
>
> Don't say: "Looks like we're still missing a few people."
> Instead say: "We have who we need for the decision. Let's go."

If the person who decides is late, start with the part that doesn't need them.

2 When you open, name the decision

Say what the meeting is for in one sentence before anything else.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "So, what did everyone want to cover?"
> Instead say: "We're here to pick between the two launch dates."
>
> Don't say: "Let's just talk through where things are."
> Instead say: "One decision today: do we ship the beta to everyone or one region first?"

If you can't say the decision in one sentence, the meeting isn't ready yet.

3 When you set it up, say what done looks like

Tell people what will be true when the meeting ends.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "I just wanted to quickly sync on this."
> Instead say: "By the end, we'll know who owns the migration."
>
> Don't say: "Let's see where we land."
> Instead say: "We're done when we have a date and an owner."

Say it at the start, then check it before you end.

4 When you share your screen, point before you present

Have it up before people join and tell them where to look.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Can everyone see my screen?"
> Instead say: "Screen's up. Look at the second table."
>
> Don't say: "Let me just find the right tab."
> Instead say: "This chart is the only thing we need today."

Close every tab you won't need before the meeting starts.

5 When there are updates, send them first

Put updates in writing before the meeting so the time goes to the decision.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Let's go around and do updates."
> Instead say: "Updates are in the doc. Any questions on them?"
>
> Don't say: "Can each team give a quick status?"
> Instead say: "I pulled every status into one page. Flag anything that's wrong."

If an update needs a discussion, give it its own spot on the agenda.

6 When the meeting goes off track, park it out loud

Name the side topic, give it an owner and a day, and go back to the decision.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Sorry, we're kind of getting off topic."
> Instead say: "That one deserves its own 20 minutes. Sam, can you set it up for Thursday? Back to the launch date. Are we going with the 14th?"

Every parked topic gets a name and a day, or it comes back next week.

Check every meeting before it starts

Run this before you send your next invite:

- [ ] Will you start on time, even if people are missing?
- [ ] Can you say the decision in one sentence?
- [ ] Did you say what done looks like?
- [ ] Is your screen ready before anyone joins?
- [ ] Did updates go out in writing first?